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Why Africa Should Lead on Governing Global Tech Giants

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Key Points

- Africa has an opportunity to develop governance frameworks that address its own needs and serve as a model for other regions. Global tech giants often exploit Africa's data resources with little reinvestment, exacerbating inequalities and creating challenges around privacy, misinformation and market monopolies.
- While there is a global consensus on the need for regulation, many countries have been unable or unwilling to act, leaving many African countries vulnerable to the unchecked practices of these corporations.
- Africa should establish a unified regulatory system through the African Union, focusing on data privacy, cybersecurity and corporate accountability, ensuring that digital ecosystems benefit local populations and reduce data exploitation.
- Promoting digital connectivity, strengthening local tech ecosystems and supporting innovation could allow Africa to reduce dependency on foreign tech giants, foster economic development and contribute to enhancing its negotiating power on the global stage.

Introduction

In recent years, the exponential rise of US-based tech giants such as Google, Meta (formerly Facebook), Amazon, Apple and Microsoft has reshaped the way the world interacts, communicates and consumes. These companies now hold vast amounts of power and influence over economies, political systems, societies and individual lives. However, as these companies continue to grow, there is an increasing consensus around the need for a comprehensive regulatory framework to govern their operations (Khanal, Zhang and Taeihagh 2025). Yet, despite widespread acknowledgment of the need for regulation, many powerful nations have either been unwilling or unable to effectively regulate these companies (Lindman, Makinen and Kasanen 2023). While Africa is often sidelined in the global conversation about technology governance, it is uniquely positioned to take a leadership role in creating a governance framework that better serves not only the continent but also the global community.

This policy brief argues that Africa's relative lack of direct benefits from tech giants, along with the enormous costs downloaded on them, and with the continent's growing influence in the digital economy, provides a unique opportunity for Africa

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to take charge. The brief explores why the current global regulatory frameworks are insufficient and how Africa can step into a leadership role to develop a regulatory system that is tailored to the continent's specific needs and values. Furthermore, it discusses how African leadership in global tech governance could serve as a model for other regions and contribute to a more balanced global order.

The Global Rise of Tech Giants and Their Governance Challenges

Over the last two decades, the world's most powerful tech companies have grown at an unprecedented rate, transforming from start-ups into multinational conglomerates with global reach (Ovide 2021). Tech giants such as Google, Meta, Apple, Amazon and Microsoft are not merely businesses: they have become central to the global economy. They dominate digital advertising, cloud computing, e-commerce and social media, controlling significant portions of the digital space. With their vast user bases and growing influence, they hold the power to shape consumer behaviour, dictate the flow of information and influence political outcomes (Nielsen and Ganter 2022). Their power extends far beyond the traditional corporate boundaries and sometimes infringes on national sovereignty.

Despite their influence, many of these companies have faced uneven and insufficient regulation across the world. There are numerous reasons for this lack of regulatory intervention. In some cases, governments have been reluctant to regulate American tech companies as a result of pressure from the United States, demand from local populations, the pace of change and complexity of the challenge or a lack of regulatory/policy capacity, among other challenges (Qu, Simes and O'Mahony 2017). This reluctance has also been exacerbated by Donald Trump's second presidency, which has included fairly direct attacks on such regulation by countries around the world, whether friend or foe (Sweney 2025). Consequently, many countries are hesitant to challenge the practices of big tech companies too aggressively for fear of stifling economic growth, losing their technological competitive edge or being subject to the ire of Trump and his increasingly illiberal approach to global trade (Alonso-Trabanco 2025). Moreover, in many instances, governments and their citizens view these companies as essential to future prosperity and national security (Cronin 2023).

However, the rise of global tech giants has also created significant challenges, particularly in terms of privacy, market monopolies, data sovereignty and the ethical implications of emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence. These challenges have prompted growing calls for greater regulation and accountability, especially as these companies increasingly influence not only economic systems but also cultural norms and political processes (Parramore 2023).

Competing interests when attempting to govern tech giants pose challenges for many states; actually governing effectively raises other issues — even when a real will to act exists. The global nature of these tech companies' operations compounds the difficulties in establishing an effective regulatory framework. Tech companies operate across borders, and the regulation of their activities often requires international cooperation (Simpson and Conner 2021). Unfortunately, achieving global consensus has been elusive, as countries often prioritize national interests or fear economic repercussions from these powerful multinational corporations and the US government — especially under Trump — on their behalf.

The governance of tech giants has been a prominent issue in developed countries; however, it is in the Global South — particularly in Africa — where the need for regulation is most acute (Musoni 2024). Africa, as both a growing consumer market for digital services and a key player in the global digital economy, is disproportionately impacted by the lack of effective regulation of these companies (Okolo 2023). Unlike some developed nations that gain considerable benefits from these companies (though whether it is a net benefit remains up for question), Africa has largely been left on the margins of the tech-driven global economy. This is in part due to limited infrastructure, low investment in innovation and systemic exclusion from global tech governance discussions, where its perspectives and needs are often overlooked by dominant powers. As a result, the continent is often left accepting global decisions made in Europe, the United States or China (Soulé 2023). This marginal position leaves African countries vulnerable to the consequences of tech companies' unchecked behaviour.

Africa's Unique Position: Opportunities and Challenges

African states stand in stark contrast to many developed countries when it comes to the regulation and governance of global tech giants. While many powerful countries are invested in maintaining a certain level of reliance on these companies due to their economic contributions, Africa's experience has been markedly different. For the most part, African nations are not receiving the same benefits from global tech companies. The continent's digital economy is growing rapidly, but the benefits remain disproportionately concentrated in the hands of American tech giants, rather than being reinvested locally (Tafese 2022). Companies such as Google, Meta and Amazon dominate the digital landscape in Africa, but the majority of the profits generated by these companies are extracted and reinvested elsewhere, leaving African countries with little control over the data and digital infrastructure within their own borders (Mano 2022).

One of the main reasons for Africa's relatively weak position is the way these companies have shaped the continent's digital ecosystem. While the internet has become more widely accessible, many African countries remain in the early stages of digital development (Oloyede et al. 2023). Across much of the continent, the internet infrastructure is still underdeveloped, and online access remains costly and unreliable for much of the population. Consequently, many Africans rely on services provided by global tech giants such as Google and Meta for access to information, social connection and e-commerce. The African Competition

Forum reported in 2024 that "Google is a *de facto* monopoly in Africa, with more than 90% market share" of search engine use (African Competition Forum 2024). Similarly, Facebook's share of the social media market has continued to generally climb on the continent hovering at just under 85 percent and with all other platforms accounting for only around 15 percent of the market.[1]

At the same time, the lack of regulation has allowed these companies to exploit Africa's vast data resources with little accountability. User data, which is often collected without adequate transparency or consent, is extracted by tech giants and used to fuel their global operations, without significant economic reinvestment into African economies (Akintolu 2025). This exploitation of African data for profit, commonly referred to as "data colonialism," exacerbates existing inequalities (Musikali 2022) and further entrenches Africa's position as a net taker in the global digital economy. Moreover, the increasing spread of disinformation, hate speech and other harmful content online has disproportionately affected African states, where regulatory frameworks are often ill-equipped to handle these issues (Okereke et al. 2021). These disproportionate effects are partly due to weak regulatory frameworks, limited digital literacy and under-resourced institutions that are unable to effectively monitor and respond to digital threats. This vulnerability exacerbates political instability, ethnic tensions and public health crises, deepening existing social and economic divides.

However, Africa's position as a marginalized participant in the global governance of tech giants does not have to remain fixed. In fact, the challenges Africa faces in digital governance present an opportunity for the continent to take the lead in developing a governance model that addresses the specific needs and priorities of the region. Africa's unique position offers several distinct advantages: the continent is experiencing rapid growth in digital usage; it has a young and tech-savvy population; and it needs more inclusive, locally appropriate solutions to address the challenges of global tech governance. Internet users increased from approximately 181 million in 2014 to around 646 million in 2024, and projections suggest this number will exceed 1.1 billion by 2029 (Tila 2025). The continent's youth population is also expanding rapidly: more than 60 percent of Africans are under the age of 25, and this demographic is expected to drive significant economic and technological transformation in the coming decades (Mpemba and Munyati 2023).

Two examples illustrate the challenges and lessons learned related to the regulation and governance of global tech giants:

- **Nigeria's data protection efforts:** In 2019, Nigeria passed the Nigeria Data Protection Regulation (NDPR), which was one of the continent's first comprehensive attempts at regulating data protection and privacy. The NDPR aims to safeguard personal data and ensure that tech giants operating in the country comply with stricter data privacy norms (Akintola and Akinpelu 2021). This regulation was a direct response to the increasing concerns over the exploitation of African data by foreign companies, who were using it without providing adequate protection or reinvestment. The NDPR imposes penalties on companies that fail to meet compliance standards, marking a significant move toward protecting African citizens' data in the face of foreign tech dominance (Udoh and Olajide 2021). However, enforcement remains a challenge due to limited local capacity and the global nature of the tech giants involved.
- **Kenya's efforts to regulate the digital economy:** Kenya provides another example where the government has made strides to curb the power of global tech companies in the region. In 2021, Kenya introduced the Data Protection Act (DPA) alongside other digital regulations that aim to manage the collection, storage and use of personal data. Additionally, the Competition Authority of Kenya has investigated and fined multinational companies such as Google and Meta for their failure to comply with local tax and data protection laws (Kevins and Brian 2022). These actions signal an attempt by Kenya to create a more equitable digital ecosystem by ensuring that foreign tech companies contribute to the local economy, particularly through taxes and responsible data practices (Erforth and Martin-Shields 2022). Despite good work being done, these efforts are often met with resistance from global companies, leading to an ongoing battle over the balance of power in the digital space.

1 See https://gs.statcounter.com/social-media-stats/all/africa.

These examples from Nigeria and Kenya show that while Africa is making progress in regulating global tech companies, the challenges of enforcement and the need for more robust frameworks remain significant. One of the key shortcomings is that, in both of the examples, the efforts are largely based on European models, and they were not adequately tailored to account for local technological, economic, or socio-cultural events. Nonetheless, they provide valuable starting places as well as lessons learned in how African nations can begin to reclaim control over their digital landscapes and use governance as a tool to foster more sustainable and equitable digital economies. Through their shortcomings, they also importantly demonstrate the imperative to seek context-specific solutions, rather than cookie-cutter approaches that assume policies can be effectively transplanted from one region to another — a lesson we should have learned long ago through decades of failed development efforts.

The Potential for Africa to Lead

Africa's position as a consumer of global tech solutions does not mean that it cannot take charge of creating governance frameworks for these tech giants. In fact, the continent has an opportunity to take a leading role in reshaping global conversations around digital regulation. Africa is home to the world's youngest population, and this demographic is increasingly engaging with the digital world, making it a hub of digital innovation (Němečková 2021). This youthful population represents a massive opportunity to develop solutions that are innovative, forward-thinking and reflective of African values.

Furthermore, Africa's digital economy is expanding rapidly, with more and more African countries developing digital strategies and initiatives aimed at harnessing the potential of technology for social and economic development. Africa's digital economy is contributing up to US$180 billion to the continent's GDP (Teleanu and Kurbalija 2022). As the continent becomes an increasingly important player in the global digital economy, the need for African-led governance frameworks grows. These frameworks can not only address Africa's unique needs but also serve as models for other regions of the world that are seeking to regulate the power of tech giants.

Africa can develop a governance framework that is informed by the specific needs and challenges faced by its diverse countries and communities. The continent is home to more than 1.4 billion people speaking more than 2,000 languages, making cultural and linguistic diversity central to designing inclusive digital policies that global tech firms often overlook (United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization 2025). At the same time, common challenges such as political instability — seen in the fact that at least 23 African countries experienced significant civil unrest or conflict in 2023 — and high levels of corruption — with 44 of 54 African countries scoring below 50 on Transparency International's Corruption Perceptions Index — highlight the need for robust accountability mechanisms in digital governance (Banoba, Mwanyumba and Kaninda 2025). Additionally, with more than 490 million Africans still lacking access to electricity as of 2023, infrastructure limitations demand tailored regulatory approaches that account for uneven access to technology (El Hillo 2025). By designing tech governance solutions that address these realities, African countries can create a regulatory system that not only protects consumers and curbs exploitation by powerful foreign platforms but also fosters homegrown innovation and ensures that the digital economy benefits all citizens.

African leadership in global tech governance could take many forms. One possibility is the establishment of pan-African regulatory frameworks, perhaps through the African Union, that could address key issues such as data privacy, digital inclusion, corporate accountability and cybersecurity. For example, the African Union Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection, also known as the Malabo Convention, could be used as a starting point for creating continent-wide regulations that prioritize data protection and digital rights. Such frameworks would also provide a foundation for African countries to work together to develop solutions that reflect their collective interests, rather than relying on regulations imposed by foreign powers.

While there are positive developments to build from out of the Malabo Convention, there are also lessons to be learned from its shortcomings. The convention has faced significant challenges due to slow ratification — only 15 countries had ratified it as of 2023, limiting its enforcement. Its lack of widespread adoption stems from limited political will, inadequate national legal frameworks and insufficient technical capacity among member states to implement its provisions effectively (Thaldar 2023).

In addition to slow ratification and limited political will, the Malabo Convention has faced other key challenges:

- **Lack of awareness and prioritization:** Many governments have not prioritized digital security legislation, often due to more immediate concerns such as poverty, conflict and health crises, which has delayed engagement with the convention's objectives.
- **Resource constraints:** Many African nations lack the financial, technical and human resources needed to implement complex cybersecurity and data protection frameworks, making compliance with the convention difficult.
- **Institutional weaknesses:** Weak or underdeveloped regulatory institutions and limited coordination among regional bodies have hindered the effective domestication and enforcement of the convention's standards.
- **Diverse legal systems:** The wide variation in legal traditions and systems across African countries makes harmonization difficult, creating obstacles to aligning national laws with the convention.
- **Private sector engagement:** There has been insufficient collaboration with the private tech sector, which plays a major role in Africa's digital ecosystem and is essential for effective cybersecurity and data governance.
- **Transnational challenges:** Cyberthreats often cross borders, but cooperation and information sharing among African nations remain limited, undermining a coordinated continental response (Carnegie Endowment for International Peace 2023).

These factors collectively have contributed to the convention's limited impact over the past decade and will be key issues to overcome if the continent is to successfully govern its digital future.

Below are two examples of countries that are making strides in digital governance and shaping their own regulatory frameworks:

- **Rwanda's vision for digital transformation:** Rwanda is positioning itself as a leader in digital governance and technological innovation on the African continent. The country's Smart Rwanda Master Plan, launched in 2015, is a comprehensive strategy designed to foster Rwanda's digital economy and enhance governance through technology. One of the key aspects of this plan is the promotion of digital inclusion, with a focus on increasing internet access and ensuring that citizens benefit from the digital transformation (Ingabire 2024).

  Over the past decade, the Smart Rwanda Master Plan has significantly advanced the country's digital transformation. Kigali was ranked Africa's top smart city in the 2023 African Smart City Index, excelling in e-governance, innovation and environmental integration. Key achievements include the expansion of 4G LTE coverage to 96.7 percent of the country; the launch of IremboGov, which offers more than 100 online government services; and the establishment of Kigali Innovation City to foster a thriving tech ecosystem.[2] Rwanda also established the Rwanda Utilities Regulatory Authority to oversee the telecom sector and ensure fair practices among digital service providers. Additionally, Rwanda has been at the forefront of data protection, with the country adopting policies that align with international standards on data privacy (Aguilar and Keenan 2023). This approach has helped Rwanda become a model for other African countries looking to leverage technology for development while ensuring that local needs are prioritized.

- **South Africa's Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA):** South Africa has made significant progress in creating a regulatory framework that addresses data protection and privacy. POPIA, which came into effect in 2021, is one of the most comprehensive data protection laws in Africa. The act regulates the collection, storage and dissemination of personal data and ensures that individuals' privacy rights are protected (Prinsloo and Kaliisa 2022). It is part of South Africa's broader digital governance efforts, which also include initiatives to promote cybersecurity and digital innovation. This law has encouraged both local

2 See https://atlasofurbantech.org/cases/rwa-smart-rwanda/.

and international tech companies to adopt more transparent and accountable practices when operating in South Africa (Adams et al. 2021).

The examples of Rwanda and South Africa both illustrate how African countries are taking proactive steps to shape their digital futures, focusing on digital inclusion, data protection and regulatory frameworks that cater to local needs while addressing the challenges posed by global tech giants. These examples show how Africa can develop governance models that reflect its unique socio-economic realities and safeguard its digital sovereignty (Soulé 2024). As with Nigeria's NDPR, Kenya's DPA and South Africa's POPIA, these data protection laws borrow key principles from the European Union's General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) — such as user consent, data minimization and breach notification — yet often lack the same enforcement capacity and institutional support. This comparison highlights that while African nations are making important strides in digital governance, effective regulation requires not just legislative alignment with global standards but also the political will and infrastructure to enforce them.

Africa's Call to Action: Policy Recommendations

Establish a Pan-African Digital Governance Framework

African nations should collaborate to create a unified, continent-wide digital governance framework under the auspices of the African Union. Overcoming the massive challenges to a unified digital governance framework is worth the effort because it would strengthen Africa's collective bargaining power with global tech companies, protect citizens' digital rights and foster a more equitable digital economy across the continent. To achieve this, African nations could adopt phased regional integration, invest in shared digital infrastructure and build legal and technical capacity through African Union-led training programs and public-private partnerships. Coordinated policy harmonization and inclusive stakeholder engagement would also help ensure that the framework both reflects Africa's diverse realities and promotes continental cohesion.

This framework should focus on key issues such as data privacy, cybersecurity, digital rights and corporate accountability, drawing on existing regional agreements such as the Malabo Convention, particularly its emphasis on harmonizing cybersecurity, personal data protection and electronic transactions laws across the continent. The convention also offers a foundational legal blueprint that, if reinforced with stronger enforcement mechanisms, wider ratification and more robust institutional support, can serve as a springboard for a more comprehensive and enforceable African Union-led framework. Its shortcomings — such as limited uptake and implementation — point to the need for sustained political commitment, capacity building and regional cooperation to ensure future efforts are both inclusive and effective. African countries should work together to craft regulations that specifically address the continent's unique needs, ensuring that the exploitation of African data by global tech giants is minimized and that digital ecosystems are inclusive and equitable. This framework could also provide a foundation for collaboration with other regions — especially those in the Global South that share similar challenges, such as Latin America, and Southeast Asia — to create a global standard for tech governance that prioritizes developing economies.

Strengthen National Data Protection Laws and Institutions

To mitigate the exploitation of African data and to safeguard the privacy of its citizens, African countries must enact robust national data protection laws that align with international best practices, including the GDPR, while considering the local contexts discussed earlier in this brief. Despite their diversity, Africa's 54 countries share common challenges, such as fragmented digital infrastructure, limited regulatory capacity and vulnerability to exploitation by powerful foreign tech companies. These shared experiences, along with growing mobile connectivity and a rapidly expanding youth population, create a strong case for continent-wide collaboration to build a unified digital governance framework that reflects Africa's collective interests and amplifies its voice on the global stage. This work includes creating or strengthening data protection authorities capable of enforcing regulations and protecting citizens' rights.

By establishing clear guidelines on data ownership, consent and the use of personal information by foreign tech giants, African nations can ensure that the digital economy serves their citizens' interests and limits data exploitation. Beyond being clear, such guidelines should be tailored to the specific needs and realities of African nations, considering factors such as local privacy concerns, socio-economic disparities and varying levels of digital literacy. For example, guidelines could include culturally sensitive consent processes that account for diverse communication practices, data protection policies that safeguard vulnerable populations, and robust mechanisms for holding foreign tech companies accountable for data breaches or exploitation.

The guidelines should promote local innovation, ensuring that data is not only protected but also leveraged to support sustainable economic growth across the continent. Countries should also consider regional cooperation to standardize data protection laws and create a united front for data sovereignty. Regional cooperation in standardizing data protection laws would not only help curb abuses by foreign tech giants but also bolster Africa's digital economy by enabling the growth of local tech start-ups. Connecting this effort with the African Continental Free Trade Area and its Protocol on Digital Trade would strengthen the case for a unified regulatory framework by ensuring that data protection standards are aligned with broader economic integration efforts. This alignment could create a more favourable environment for homegrown tech companies, facilitating cross-border trade, data flow and innovation while fostering a competitive digital economy that benefits African businesses and consumers alike.

Promote Digital Inclusion and Connectivity Initiatives

For Africa to fully benefit from its growing digital economy, it is crucial to prioritize digital inclusion. African governments should invest in infrastructure projects to improve internet access, especially in rural and underserved areas, and reduce the cost of connectivity. Investing in infrastructure projects is crucial not just to improve internet access but also to reduce the continent's dependency on foreign tech giants' infrastructure, which often comes with limitations on control, pricing and data sovereignty.

By building more localized and resilient digital infrastructure, African governments could increase competition, lower costs and offer more equitable access to services, potentially creating space for local tech companies to thrive and innovate. This would also reduce the continent's reliance on American companies, allowing African governments to have more influence over digital services and data usage within their borders. Public-private partnerships with tech companies should be incentivized to ensure that digital technologies are not only accessible but also affordable. These initiatives will provide a broader segment of the African population with the tools necessary to participate in and benefit from the digital economy.

Establish an African Digital Trade and Technology Forum

African governments should create a "Digital Trade and Technology Forum" to facilitate dialogue between governments, the private sector, civil society and regional tech innovators. Doing so through the African Union could serve to leverage its pan-African mandate to ensure broad participation and coordination, though the challenge would lie in balancing the African Union's oversight with the need for agility and responsiveness from private sector and civil society actors, which may sometimes be hindered by the African Union's bureaucratic processes. This forum would serve as a space for sharing best practices, discussing digital trade policies and negotiating terms with global tech companies on issues such as data sovereignty, market access and fair competition. It would also serve as one potential avenue to help African countries collectively address concerns related to tech monopolies, the regulation of online content and the ethical implications of emerging technologies. Through this forum, Africa can increase its presence in global discussions on digital trade and technology governance, advocating for policies that prioritize the continent's development needs.

Encourage Local Tech Ecosystem Development and Innovation

With regard to longer-term goals, African governments should implement policies that promote the development of local tech ecosystems. Despite significant and obvious challenges to doing so, over time such efforts should include investing in tech incubators, accelerators and educational programs aimed at nurturing African start-ups and tech innovators. Providing access to financing and markets, as well as creating a regulatory environment that supports local innovation, will help foster a competitive digital industry that is more aligned with Africa's unique needs. By supporting local tech companies, Africa can reduce its dependency on foreign tech giants and create homegrown solutions that better serve its population, potentially providing alternatives to existing global platforms. These efforts will also strengthen Africa's negotiating power with international tech companies, ensuring that their operations contribute more to local economies.

Conclusion

Africa stands at a crossroads in terms of global tech governance. While the continent has historically been a passive recipient of policies shaped by other nations, the challenges posed by tech giants provide a clear opportunity for Africa to take a leading role in the global conversation about digital governance. By leveraging its growing digital economy, young population and unique challenges, Africa can create a governance model that prioritizes its own needs while also providing a blueprint for other regions. Africa's leadership in this area would not only benefit the continent but also contribute to a more equitable and balanced global digital economy. The time for Africa to lead on the governance of global tech giants is now.

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